

PERSONAL LEADERSHIP SERIES

The Wheel and the Arrow

A Disciple's Guide to Personal Leadership and Goal Setting

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The life you live tomorrow is shaped by the decisions and actions you commit to paper today.

The Wheel and the Arrow
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Bible passages: own translation from the Hebrew and Greek by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé.

Inspired by the personal-development tradition, including the work of Paul J. Meyer. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Leadership Management International.

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Also as an app: https://hannesnortje.github.io/Wheel_and_Arrow/

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CHAPTER 1

Introduction: Being and Becoming

> *I am sure of this: he who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus.*
>
> **Philippians 1:6**

Most books on leadership are about leading other people. **Personal leadership** comes before that: it is the quiet, daily work of leading yourself. It does not switch on at nine and off at five. It shows in *who you are* – at work, at home, among your neighbours, and when no one is watching at all.

Many people find it hard to set a clear course for their lives, not because they lack ambition, but because they have seldom stopped to look honestly at where they stand. If you do not know where you are, you cannot plan the road to where you want to be.

This booklet helps you build that road. It connects who you are today – your **Being** – with the person you are growing into – your **Becoming**. You will name the values that really drive you, notice where you have simply been living by other people's expectations, and learn to put your goals in writing. Along the way you will discover more capacity in yourself than you expected.

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CHAPTER 2

Defining Success: The Whole Person

> *Each one should test his own work. Then he can take pride in himself alone, and not in comparison with someone else. For each one will carry his own load.*
>
> **Galatians 6:4–5**

What is success? For many people it is a place you arrive at – a certain income, a title, the admiration of others. This booklet works with a different definition, coined by Paul J. Meyer:

> **Success is the progressive realisation of worthwhile, predetermined personal goals.** — Paul J. Meyer

Three words in this definition carry the weight:

- **Progressive:** success is not a finish line but a direction. You are already succeeding while you are moving toward a goal that matters.
- **Predetermined:** success seldom happens by accident. It grows out of decisions made ahead of time.
- **Personal:** your goals must come from your own convictions and values, not from the pressure of what others expect of you.

Six areas of one life

Life does not come in separate compartments. A career that flourishes while your health collapses is not success; neither is a growing bank balance bought with a strained marriage.

We are whole people. Trouble at home follows us to work, and worry at work sits down with us at the dinner table. That is why this booklet looks at life as one whole with six areas:

Ethics & Values – your convictions, your spiritual life and the principles you live by.	**Mind & Learning** – how you grow in knowledge, understanding and skill.
Society & Community – friendships, service and your place among other people.	**Body & Health** – energy, fitness, food and rest.
Family & Home – your spouse, your children and the home you share.	**Work & Finances** – your calling at work, how you do it, and how you handle money.

Personal leadership keeps these six areas in view together, so that they support one another instead of competing.

Measured against your own potential

The question is not "Am I doing better than others?" but "Am I becoming who I could be?"

Comparing ourselves with others is the quickest way to feel unsuccessful. There is always someone further ahead, so the comparison never ends. And even when we seem to be doing better than a colleague or a relative, a single setback can show how much of our own ability we have never used. The only comparison that tells the truth is with yourself.

Three convictions help you measure success in this way:

- **Your potential cannot be measured.** No one can draw the outer line of what you are able to learn and become. Life keeps proving this: challenges we never saw coming draw out strengths we did not know we had. Often the tightest limits are the ones we have drawn ourselves.
- **Much of what you could do is still unused.** Most of us have gifts and abilities we have never really developed – a reserve waiting to be discovered.

- **Growth takes deliberate effort.** That reserve does not open up by itself. Success, in Meyer's sense, is the steady realisation of goals that you set yourself and that stretch you toward what you could become.

CHAPTER 3

The Inner Foundation: Enthusiasm and Self-Image

> *Do not let yourselves be pressed into the mould of this age, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you can test and discern what the will of God is – what is good, pleasing and perfect.*
>
> **Romans 12:2**

Before you plan outward across the six areas of your life, look at the ground you are standing on: your **inner foundation**. Two things largely decide how far you are willing to stretch – the enthusiasm with which you meet life, and the picture you carry of yourself.

Recovering enthusiasm

Watch a child: curious, flexible, ready to try anything, not yet afraid of failing. Somewhere on the way to adulthood much of that gets lost. Three things wear it down:

- **The weight of daily duties.** The busier we become, the shorter our view. We see the next task and miss the possibilities around us.
- **The pull to fit in.** Family, school, work and society all shape us to fit the expected pattern. The more we bend ourselves to be accepted, the more our own motivation and creativity fade.
- **A learned fear of failure.** Children learn by trying, failing and trying again. Adults grow sensitive to mistakes, especially if parents, teachers or early employers treated every error harshly. In the end we stop risking anything and play it safe.

> Measuring success against your own potential means deliberately leaving these influences behind. Part of personal leadership is to recover something of the openness, energy and hope with which you once met life as a child.

A healthier self-image

A better self-image is not a coat of positive thinking painted over doubt. It grows from a changed attitude toward yourself, from the inside.

We tend to live in line with the person we believe we are. A poor self-image works like a low ceiling: it limits what we attempt and lets unspoken fears and doubts make our decisions. Five things help to build a healthier self-image:

- **See that you are unique.** There is no one else exactly like you, so there is no one you need to measure yourself against. Knowing and valuing your strengths gives you a quiet inner security.
- **Accept yourself honestly.** Accept yourself as you are – strengths and weaknesses, advantages and limits. Name your weaknesses plainly, as facts, before you set goals to work on them.
- **Speak true words to yourself.** Short statements about who you want to be and how you want to live can help, especially when they are true and believable. Repeated over time, they push back the old voices of doubt and fear.
- **Reach small goals.** Success builds on success. Each short-term goal you reach shows you what you are capable of and strengthens your confidence.
- **Make peace with mistakes.** Mistakes are not disasters or proof of weakness; they are part of how everyone learns. Seen this way, a setback becomes a step to build on rather than a stone to trip over.

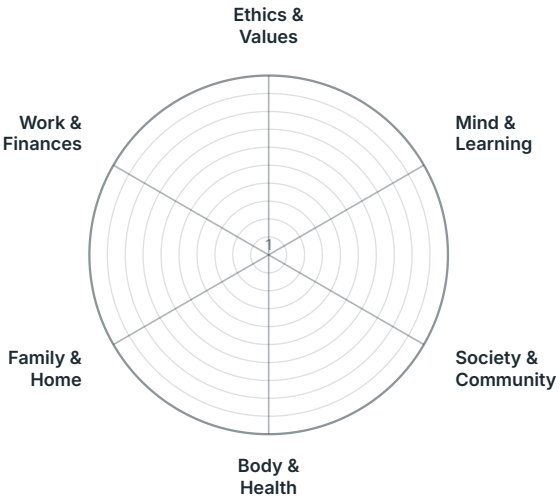
CHAPTER 4

The Wheel of Life: Where You Stand Today

> *And Jesus kept growing in wisdom and in stature, and in favour with God and with people.*
>
> **Luke 2:52**

To know where you are going, you need an honest look at where you are today.

The **Wheel of Life** gives you a picture of how satisfied you are in each of the six areas. A full-page copy is at the back of this booklet (see *The Wheel of Life – Worksheet*), and you can also fill it in online.



The six areas, scored from 1 (centre) to 10 (rim).

Self-assessment

For each area, ask yourself: "*Measured against the standard I have set for myself, where am I today on a scale of 1 to 10?*"

- **1** (at the centre) means: not satisfied at all.
- **10** (at the rim) means: completely satisfied.

Instructions

1. Give each of the six areas a score from 1 to 10.
2. Mark the score on that area's spoke of the wheel.
3. Join the marks with a line to see the shape of your wheel today.

> **The lesson of the wheel** Is your wheel round, or does it have dents and flat sides? A wheel with a 9 for work and a 2 for health will give you a very bumpy ride. The aim is to let the wheel grow outward while it stays round.

Score your wheel again in about three months and compare the two shapes.

CHAPTER 5

The Mechanism of Goal Setting

> *Brothers and sisters, I do not consider that I have already taken hold of it. But one thing I do: forgetting what lies behind and stretching out toward what lies ahead, I press on toward the mark, for the prize of God's upward call in Christ Jesus.*
>
> **Philippians 3:13–14**

5.1 What is a goal?

A goal is not a daydream or a vague wish. Daydreams are a way of escaping reality; they seldom ask anything of us.

A real goal is **the first step into concrete action**. It gives your thinking a track to run on – focus, direction and momentum.

Why write it down?

You may have heard of a famous study in which only 3% of a Yale (or Harvard) class had written goals – and twenty years later were wealthier than all the others together. That study never took place; Yale has searched its records and found nothing.

There is, however, a real study. The psychologist **Dr Gail Matthews** (Dominican University of California) set out to test the claim herself and presented her results in 2007. She divided 149 adults from many professions at random into five groups and followed them for four weeks:

Group	What they did	Result
1	Only thought about their goals	lowest progress
2	Wrote their goals down	clearly more progress than group 1

Group	What they did	Result
3–4	Also wrote action steps; group 4 shared them with a friend	more again
5	Did all of this and sent a friend a weekly progress report	the most progress

It was a small, short study, presented at a conference rather than published in a journal, but it points the same way as decades of research by Edwin Locke and Gary Latham: clear, specific, challenging goals lead to better results than a vague "I'll do my best". And three things help most – **writing the goal down, committing to concrete steps, and being accountable to someone.** Those are exactly the parts of the Goal Planning Worksheet.

Writing your goals down:

- **helps you focus**, because it becomes easier to say no to distractions;
- **gives you a yardstick**, so you can see your real progress;
- **turns an idea into a commitment** you have made to yourself;
- **saves time and energy**, because your priorities for the day become clear.

5.2 The anatomy of a SMART goal

A clear, specific goal works on two levels. It focuses your attention and effort – and when you tie it to concrete plans ("when this happens, I will do that"), your right responses become almost automatic, even when you are not thinking about the goal. Shape each goal with the **SMART** pattern:

S	**Specific**	Clear and unambiguous. Not "I want to save money", but "I am building an emergency fund."
M	**Measurable**	There are concrete markers of progress – numbers, percentages or milestones (e.g. "three times a week").
A	**Attainable**	The goal stretches you but remains realistic with the time, means and limits you have.

R	**Relevant & Realistic**	It fits your deepest values and the other areas of your wheel, and it suits this season of your life.
T	**Time-bound**	It has a clear target date. A goal without a date is a wish that can always be postponed.

5.3 Using the Goal Planning Worksheet

The *Goal Planning Worksheet* at the back of this booklet (and in the app) is the working heart of the whole process. This is what each section is for:

Section	Why it matters
Life area & dates	Places the goal in one area of your wheel and gives it dates (started, target, achieved), so it keeps a healthy urgency.
The goal	The SMART statement, written in the positive present tense ("I am...", "I do..." rather than "I will..."), so that you can already picture it.
Why it matters	Goals need a reason that moves you. Write down what you gain by reaching it and what you avoid.
What could get in the way	Expect resistance. Obstacles you have named beforehand (time, fear, pressure) are far less likely to derail you.
How I'll handle it	A plan for each obstacle – so that a roadblock becomes a detour you have already mapped.
Action steps	The big goal broken into small, manageable steps, each with its own date, so that nothing is postponed.
Who should know	Accountability makes follow-through more likely. Name the people who will support you and ask how you are doing.
How I'll track progress	A plan is only as good as its review. Say exactly when and how you will check (e.g. "every Sunday evening in my journal").
Worth it?	A last check: does the goal fit your values, and are you willing to pay the price in time, effort and money?
Reminders & pictures	Short sentences for difficult moments, and pictures or cues – and where you will put them – that keep the goal in front of you.

5.4 A completed example

This is what a finished worksheet might look like for a goal in the area Work & Finances.

LIFE AREA

Work & Finances · Started: 1 October 2025 · Target date: 31 December 2025 · Achieved on: [pending]

THE GOAL

"I am saving 1,500 USD in a dedicated emergency fund by automating a 500 USD transfer on the 1st of October, November and December."

WHY IT MATTERS

What I gain Peace of mind, less stress in my marriage, and protection for my family against unexpected costs without relying on credit cards.

What I avoid The anxiety of living from pay cheque to pay cheque, the pain of high-interest debt, and arguments about money at home.

What could get in the way	How I'll handle it
Impulse spending at the weekend.	A fixed cash-only budget for weekends; the cards stay at home.
Forgetting to make the transfer.	An automatic recurring transfer on payday in the banking app.

ACTION STEPS

1. Set up the automatic 500 USD transfer in the banking app. · Due: 1 Oct · Reviewed: 1 Oct · Done: Yes
2. Check the bank statement every Sunday evening. · Due: Weekly · Reviewed: Sundays · Done: Ongoing
3. Cancel subscriptions I don't need (saves about 40 USD a month). · Due: 5 Oct · Reviewed: 5 Oct · Done: Yes

WHO SHOULD KNOW

- My spouse – so that we plan household spending together and keep each other accountable.
- My mentor – who asks about my progress at our meetings every two weeks.

HOW I'LL TRACK PROGRESS

A habit tracker on my phone to tick off each transfer, and a look at the account balance on the 1st of every month.

WORTH IT?

Does this fit what I value? ☑ **No**
Is the time, effort and cost worth it? ☑ **No**

ENCOURAGING REMINDER

"Financial discipline is a form of self-respect."

PICTURE SUCCESS

A printed screenshot of the savings account at 1,500 USD, taped inside my diary.

CHAPTER 6

Taking the First Steps

> *Commit your works to the* LORD*, and your plans will stand firm.*
>
> **Proverbs 16:3**

Now it is your turn. Personal leadership only becomes real when you act on it.

Do not overwhelm yourself with a long list of complicated goals. Choose **one meaningful goal with real priority** for each of the six areas of your wheel.

Use the blank *Goal Planning Worksheet* to write your first six goals. Write each one in the positive present tense, and anchor it in the reason it matters to you.

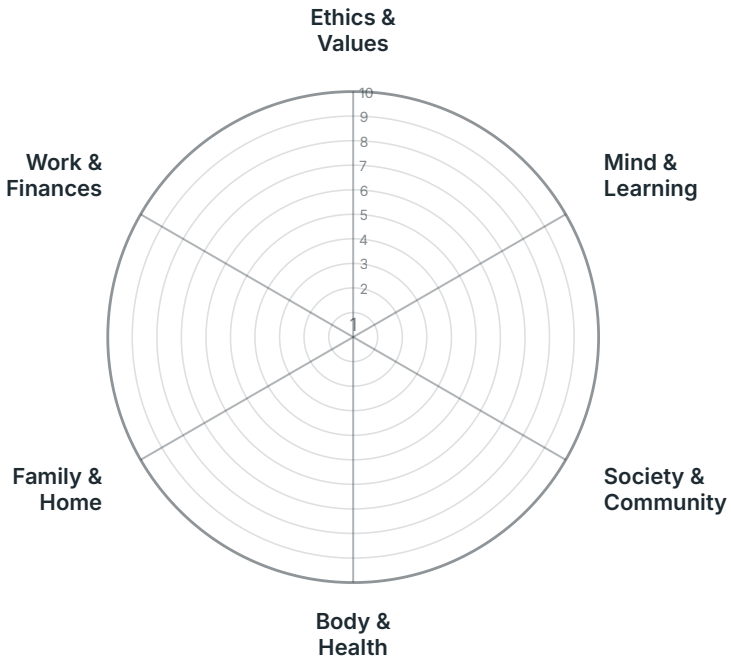
> Remember: the life you live tomorrow is shaped by the decisions and actions you commit to paper today.

WORKSHEET

The Wheel of Life – Worksheet

Score each area from 1 (centre) to 10 (rim), mark the spoke, then join the marks.

Name _____ Date _____



WORKSHEET

Goal Planning Worksheet

Turn an intention into a dated, trackable plan.

Life area	Started	Target date	Achieved on

THE GOAL

Make it SMART – specific, measurable, attainable, relevant/realistic, time-bound.

WHY IT MATTERS

What I gain by reaching it – and what I avoid.

WHAT COULD GET IN THE WAY

HOW I'LL HANDLE IT

ACTION STEPS

#	Action step	Due	Reviewed	Done
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				

WHO SHOULD KNOW

HOW I'LL TRACK PROGRESS

WORTH IT?

Does this fit what I value? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Is the time, effort and cost worth it? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Yes, but later

ENCOURAGING REMINDER

PICTURE SUCCESS

✓ **When it's done, keep this sheet with your wins.**